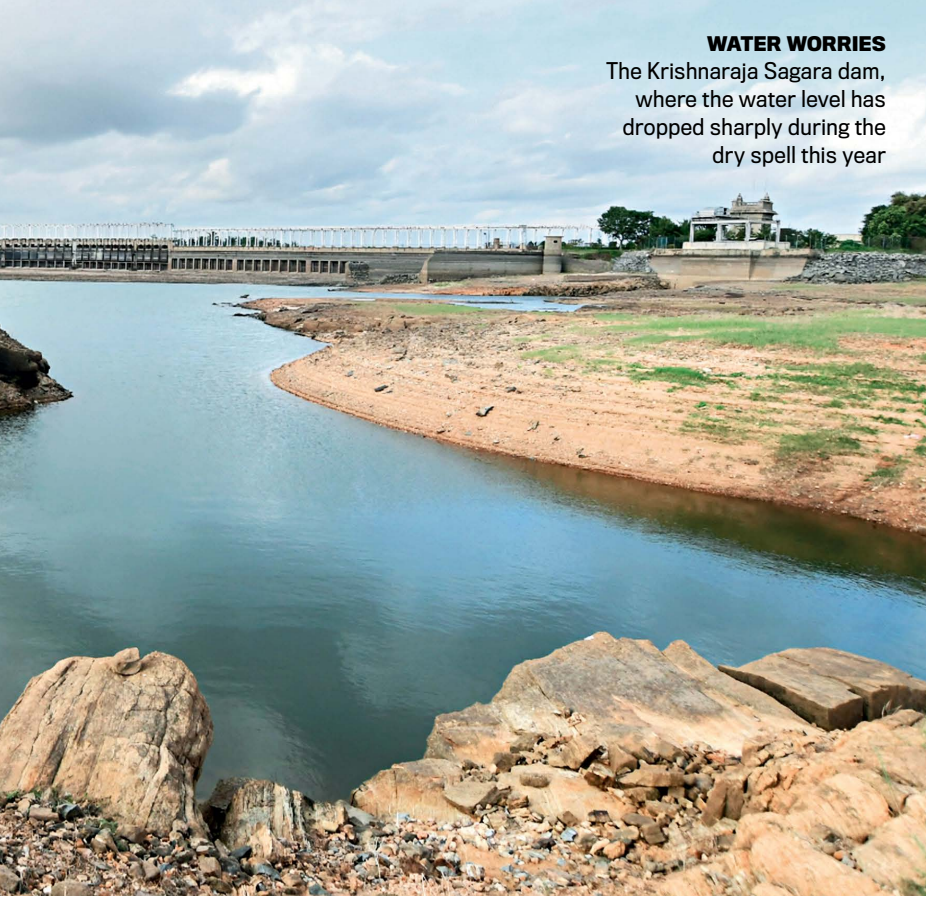


WATER WORRIES
The Krishnaraja Sagara dam, where the water level has dropped sharply during the dry spell this year

MADHUSUDHAN SR

try after Rajasthan. Over the past two decades, says Nagendra, the state has seen 11 drought and four flood years.

Kurubur Shanthakumar, president of the Karnataka Sugarcane Growers Association, is reminded of the severe drought of 2002-2003. "This year could be just as intensive, or worse," he says. According to officials, as many as 62 taluks were drought-stricken by the third week of August. By September, joint surveys were being conducted in 136 to ascertain the ground situation. "For August, the drought was severe and had a terminal effect on crops," says Karnataka revenue minister Krishna Byregowda.

The crisis has led to a political tussle, with the opposition Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) accusing the government of dragging its feet over formally declaring drought-hit taluks. In turn, chief minister Siddaramaiah has blamed the updated 2020 Manual for Drought Management, whose 'one-size-fits-all approach', he said, was proving onerous. "Despite drought-like conditions in several taluks, we haven't been able to meet the existing parameters for declaring drought, which is leaving our farmers without critical support," Siddaramaiah said in a letter in August to Union agriculture minister Narendra Singh Tomar. He sought a review of the current parameters, arguing that each of Karnataka's 14 agro-climatic zones faced distinct challenges, requiring region-specific criteria. The CM has said the government will likely take a decision on declaring drought this week after taking into account updated ground reports.

Pressure is mounting on another front: farmers' protests over the release of Cauvery water into Tamil Nadu. Sarvodaya Karnataka Party's Darshan Puttanaiah, whose assembly constituency Melukote lies along the Krishnaraja Sagara reservoir, the lifeline of the Cauvery basin, says with crop damage already imminent, the next concern is drinking water now. "With the current state of affairs, we won't be able to last long," he says, adding that the inflow into the Cauvery won't suffice for even Bengaluru's needs, let alone those of other districts in the basin.

THE DROUGHT SITUATION IN KARNATAKA HAS REIGNITED THE CONTENTIOUS CAUVERY ISSUE

Last month, Tamil Nadu took the water-sharing issue to the Supreme Court. While Karnataka complied with the orders of the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) to release water until September 12, it told the court that releasing more water may not be feasible. A political blame-game has ensued on this as well, with the BJP accusing the government of mishandling the matter from the beginning, and the ruling Congress, in turn, blaming the BJP for politicising the issue despite extending its support at an all-party meet last month. On September 13, Siddaramaiah urgently convened a second all-party meeting soon after a recommendation by the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (which assists the CWMA) to release 5,000 cusecs of water daily for another 15 days. Various legal options were discussed in the meeting, including appealing to the committee to reconsider its recommendation or taking an all-party delegation of MPs to the prime minister.

Between June 1 and September 11 this year, Karnataka released 37.7 TMC of water into Tamil Nadu, as against 99.8 TMC in a normal year. The inflow into the Cauvery, it says, was 54 per cent lower than the 30-year average. Consequently, the live storage in Karnataka's four reservoirs in the river basin stands at 53.3 TMC, as against 103.3 TMC last year. And the total water needed for drinking, irrigation and industries between now and July 2024 is estimated to be 106.2 TMC, says Siddaramaiah, explaining the state's predicament. "We are not in a position to release water to Tamil Nadu according to the SC orders," he told reporters after the all-party meeting. While Karnataka mulls its options, the matter is expected to come up in the SC next week now. ■